SOCIAL FINANCE

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Data and Tech Standards for Children's Social Care

Placement Standards Working Group

29th July 2025

Get Ready:
Go to www.menti.com
Enter code **3801 0371**

PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL

Things to be aware of

Conflicts of interest – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk.

Anti-competitive activities – Please inform the chair / secretariat if you think there is a risk of anti-competitive activity.

Intellectual Property - If you are concerned about the use of your contributions, please contact the secretariat.

Meeting Recording - We may record the meeting and using AI transcription tools.

Get Ready:
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Principles for group

1. Every voice matters
2. Please join in on the conversation, we don’t want this to be one way
3. If you’re happy to, keep your camera on
4. Please raise your hand if you want to come in, or drop your ideas in the chat
5. Respect the diverse viewpoints in the room, assume positive intent and remain open for different experiences

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Agenda

1. Introduction to the programme
2. Background: what problem are we solving with the placement standard?
3. How placement standard working group will function
4. Break
5. Placement Standard workshop

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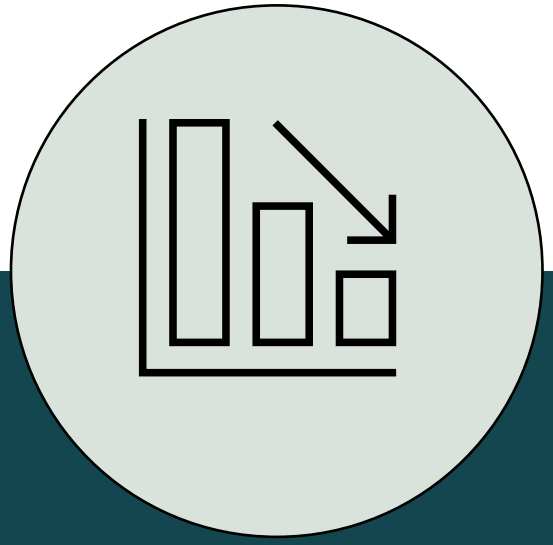
Programme Overview

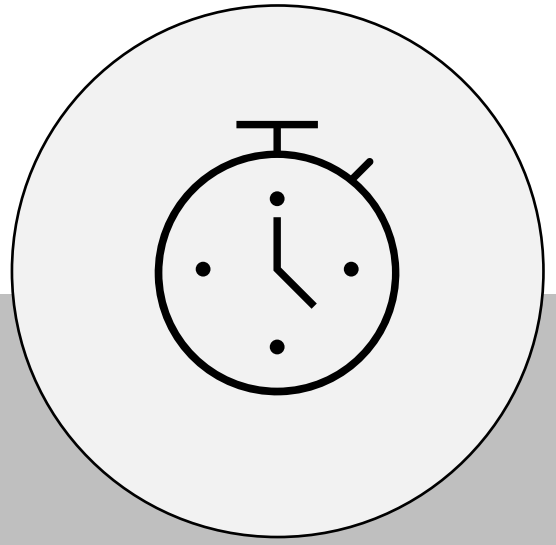
Our partnership will spend the next three years **developing data and tech standards for Children's Social Care** and **creating the conditions for success** for those standards.

We're interested in using standards to drive four key benefits:

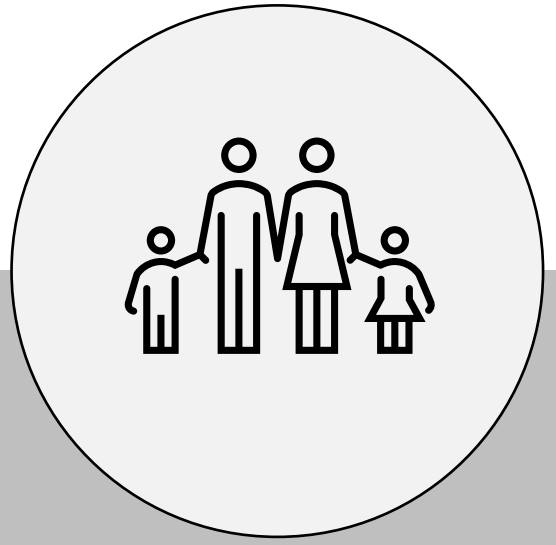
Improved data sharing to support safeguarding decisions



Better data analysis and strategic decision making



Improved productivity for social workers and a reduction in tech inhibiting processes



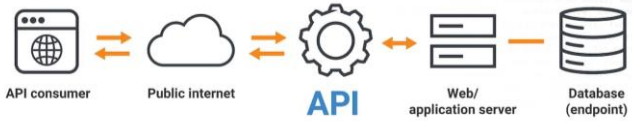
Increased power sharing with children and families

FOCUS FOR THIS GROUP

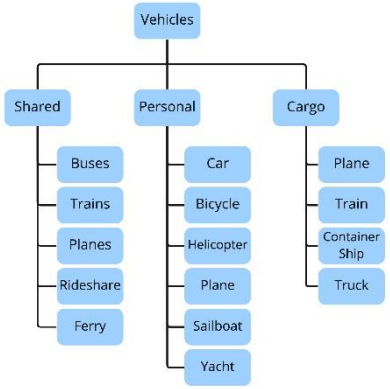
Data and tech standards allow for consistency in how data is collected, used and shared.

Standards in everyday life

Data and tech standards



Date 1(DD.MM.YYYY)	Date 2 (DD.MM.YYYY)
5-Feb-2019	05-02-19 0:00
05/02/2019 00:00:00	05/02/2019 00:00:00
5-Feb-2019	February 5, 2019
05/02/2019 00:00:00	February 5, 2019
05-06-19 0:00	June 5, 2019
05-06-19 0:00	05/06/2019 00:00:00
05/16/2019 00:00:00	05/16/2019 00:00:00
05/21/2019 00:00:00	05/21/2019 00:00:00



We generated a long list of use cases and prioritised two

Social Work recording and sensemaking

- Information capture
- Information retrieval

Children and families' experience

- Coproduction and input
- Access to records
- Carer experience

Care market management

- Care placement market analysis
- Brokerage and monitoring of care placements and providers

Business intelligence and analytics

- Data richness and reporting
- National data flows

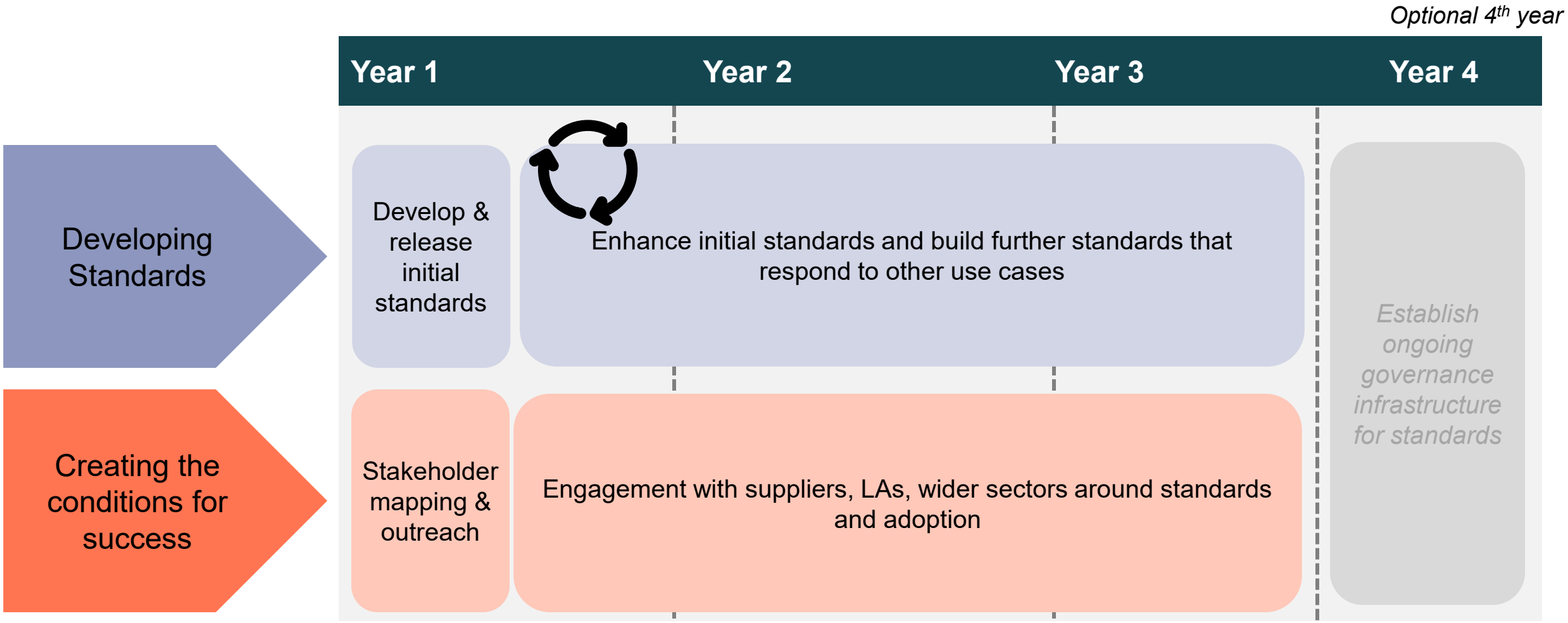
Multi-agency information sharing

- A multi-agency view of the child
- Multi-agency input into a child's record
- Interagency data transfers

Procurement and implementation

- CMS procurement and implementation

What might the next 3 years look like to help us solve the problems in the market using standards?



Introductions and expectations

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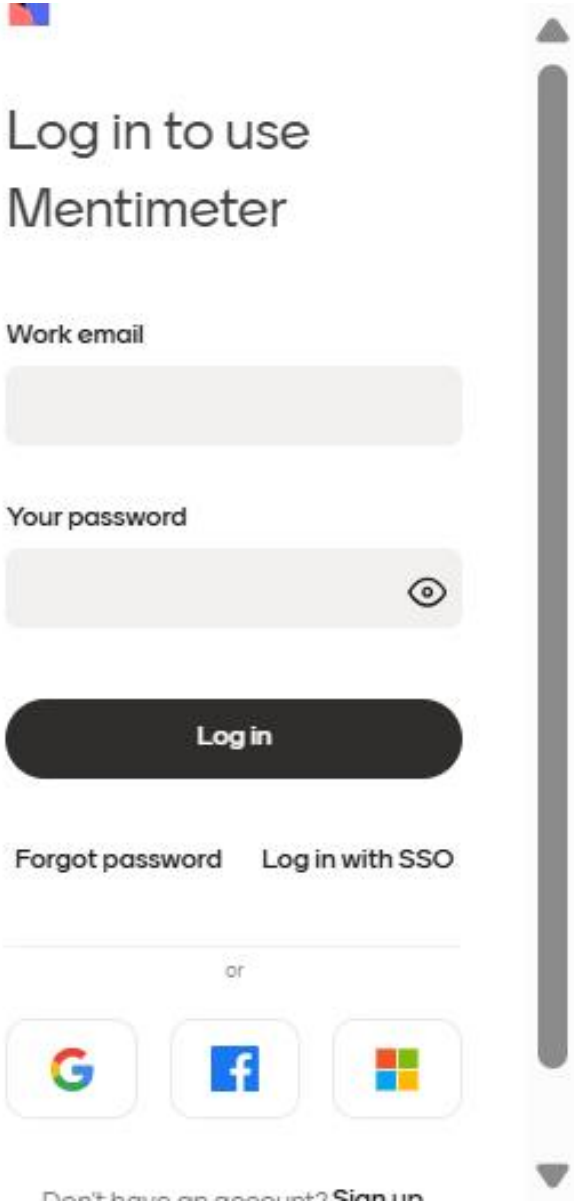

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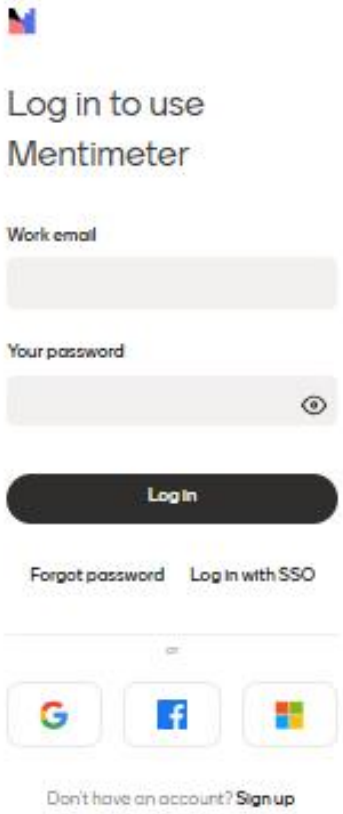

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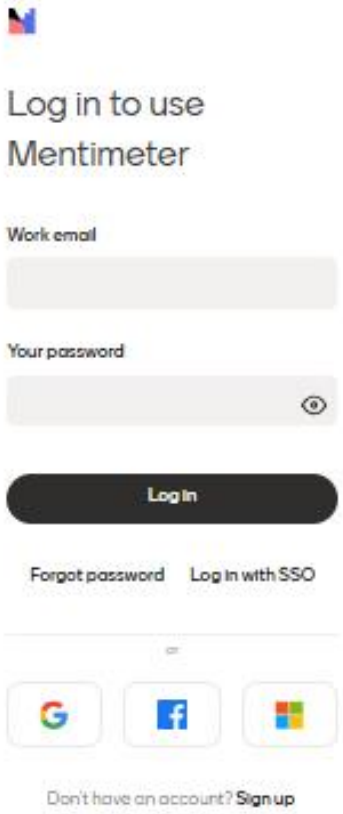

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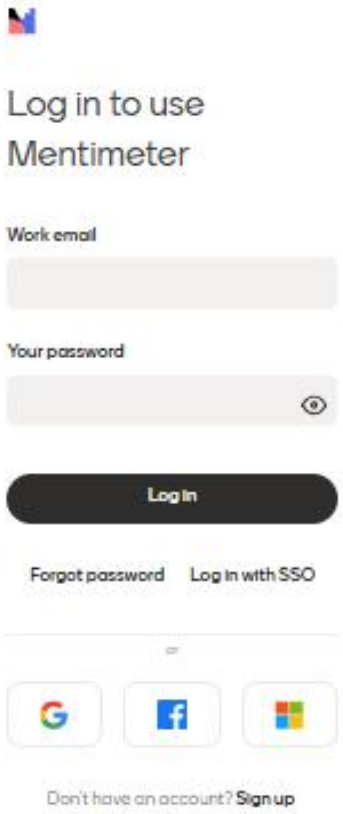

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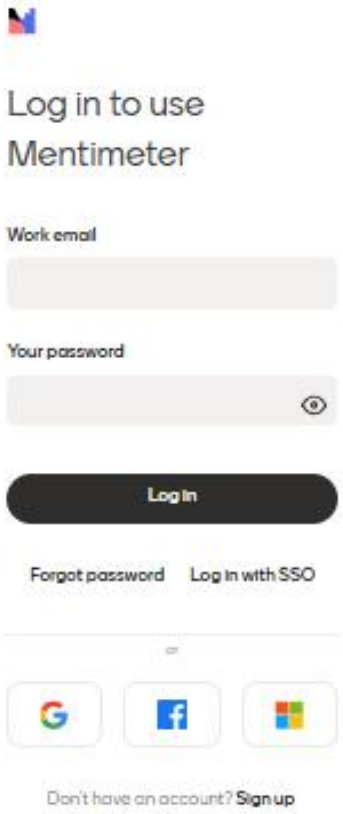


The problem we are solving (and how we'll solve it)

Roadmap for placement standards

	MAIN SCOPE FOR NOW		OUT OF SCOPE FOR NOW
	Primary use cases we are solving for	**Use cases the standard may indirectly support**	**Future use cases we may target later on**
Use cases supporting **strategic analysis**	**Better Sufficiency Analysis**	Financial forecasting and budgeting	Contract monitoring Evidencing opportunities for prevention
Use cases supporting **frontline operations**		Contract negotiation	Placement finding Child-level outcomes tracking Care Planning

Roadmap for placement standards

	MAIN SCOPE FOR NOW		OUT OF SCOPE FOR NOW
	Primary use cases we are solving for	**Use cases the standard may indirectly support**	**Future use cases we may target later on**
Use cases supporting **strategic analysis**	**Better Sufficiency Analysis** Answer: "what type of provision is needed where and in what volumes? And what is the business case for doing it, with what combination of partners?"	Financial forecasting and budgeting	Contract monitoring Evidencing opportunities for prevention
Use cases supporting **frontline operations**		Contract negotiation	Placement finding Child-level outcomes tracking Care Planning

Why the Placement Standard matters

Care market costs are unsustainable and child outcomes poor

Market intelligence is key but hard without shared (data) ‘language’

We can build on existing momentum in the sector to quickly have an impact

Many others are working to standardise data – we should build on this learning

Placement Cost Datasets and Tools

For example:
Southwest Sufficiency dataset
Placements North West dataset
White Rose placement dataset
Southeast placement cost dataset
Care Cubed

E-Brokerage Tools

For example:
CarePlace
West Mids Procurement Platform
Adam

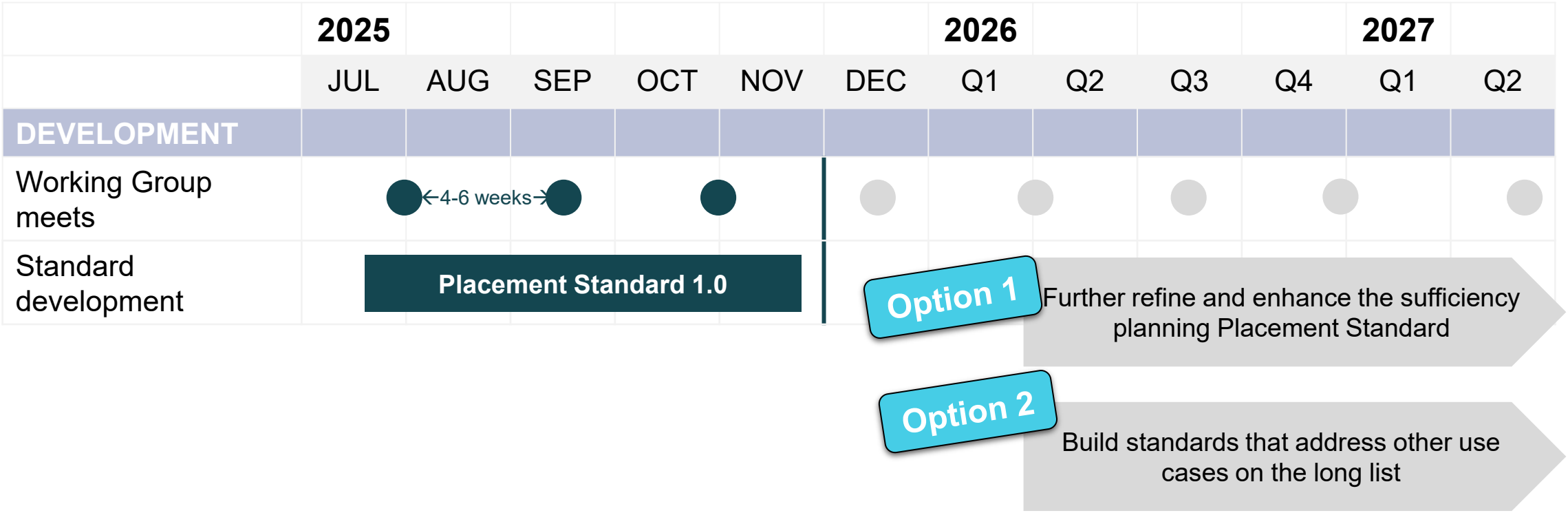
Assessment and Planning Tools

For example:
BERRI
CANS (TCOM)
IMPOWER Valuing Care

Easy – Identifying the child and identifying the placement

Hard – Defining needs and costs in a way that balances analytical power with reduced administrative burden

Placement Standard timeline



Proposed objectives for Placement Standard workstream

So that…

1. **Standard Dramatically Improves Sufficiency Analysis**

   LAs can answer: **what type of provision is needed where and in what volumes**? And what is the business case for doing it in each LA (or in partnership)?

2. **Standard Is Easy to Adopt**

   Placements teams can **enter the data in 90 seconds** or less

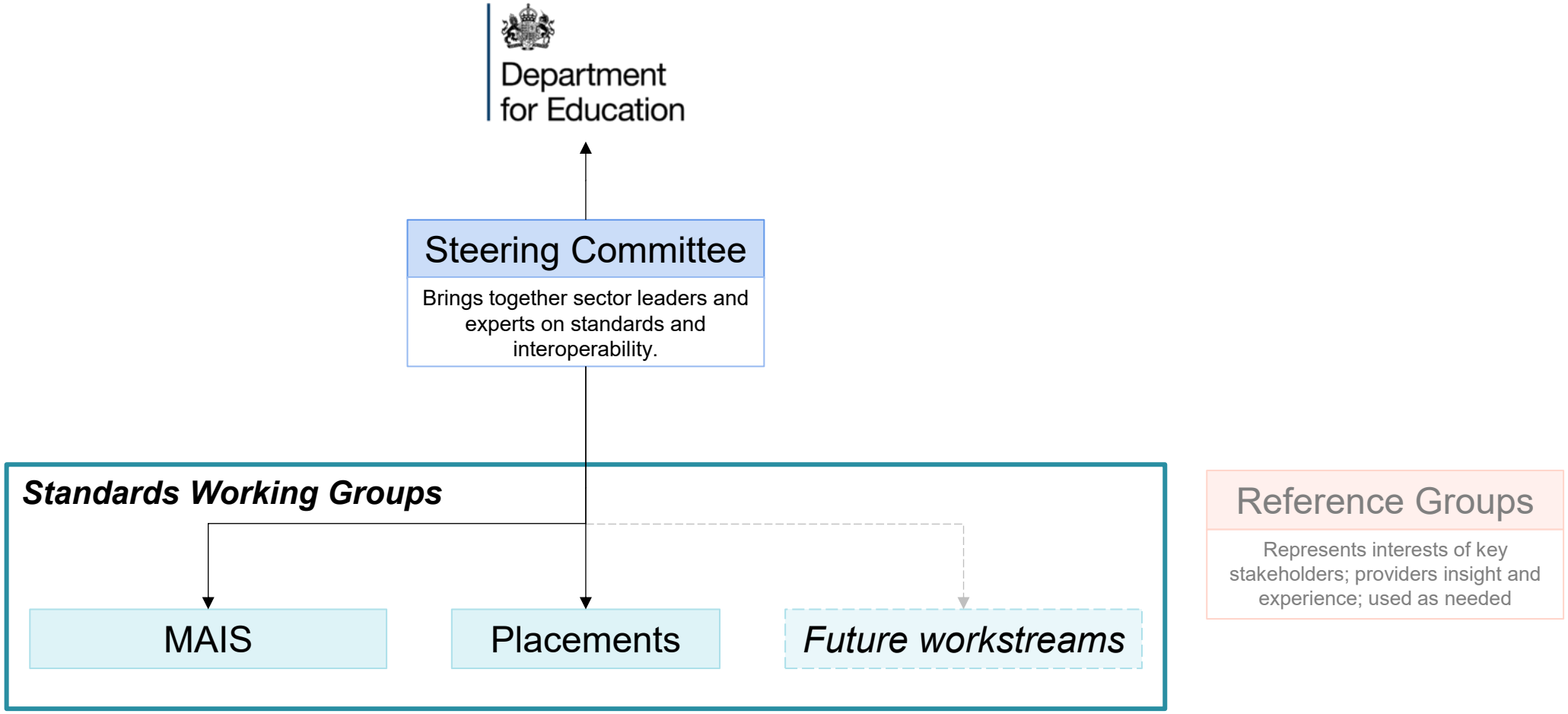
3. **Implementation Support is Effective and Affordable**

   LAs are able to implement and **benefit from a new standard quickly** within existing resource

Break for discussion

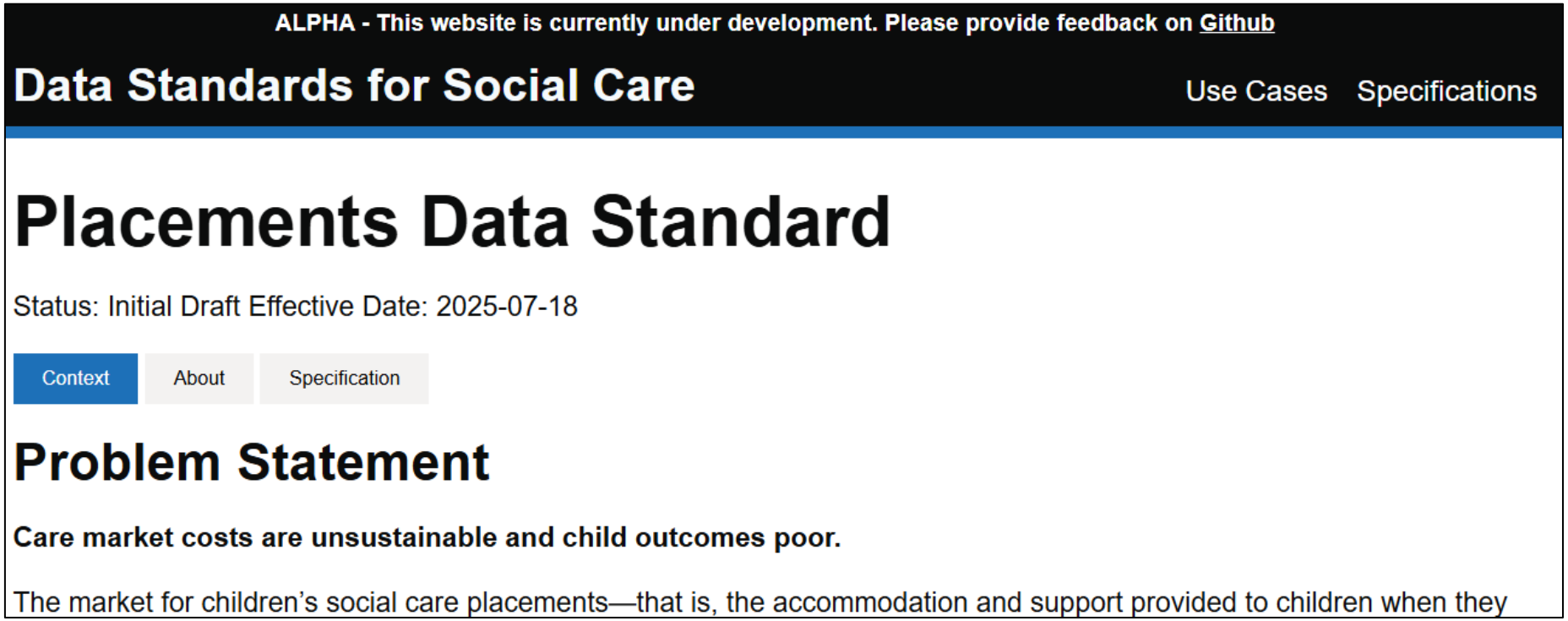
How will the Standards Working Groups work?

Programme Governance



Github

GitHub is a powerful online workspace where teams can store, manage, and collaborate on projects.



Visit: socialcaredata.github.io

5 min tea break

Placement standard workshop

Use cases priority-setting

NOW (decided by Steering Committee)	NEXT (to be decided later this year based on Working Group input)	AT SOME POINT (Long list of use cases based on Working Group input)
Better Sufficiency Analysis	?	Home search?
		Outcomes tracking?
		Contract monitoring?
		Price comparisons?
		What else…?

Consider:
- *Burden of change on LAs*
- *CMS supplier changes*
- *Need for new tech infrastructure*

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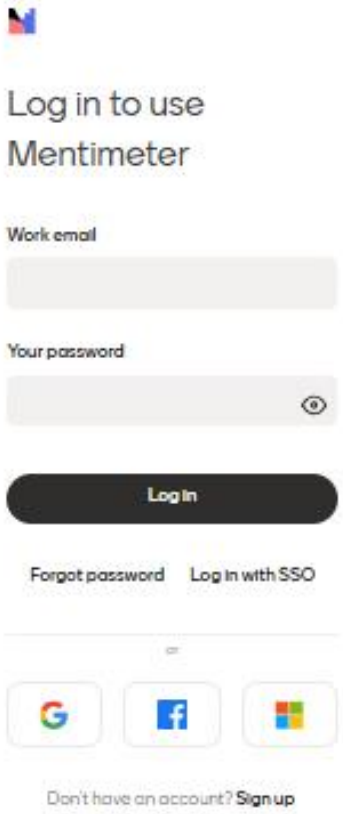

What sort of analysis will the standard 'unlock'?

Job	Some of the analysis unlocked by placement standard
Better Sufficiency Analysis	✓ What is the missing provision that would allow us to minimise: - unnecessary separation of siblings - unnecessary out of area placements - unnecessary displacement from foster to residential care ✓ What is the business case for creating this provision? ✓ What are the distinctive drivers of costs in our LA?
Financial planning	✓ Forecasting annual costs ✓ Scenario modelling
Contract negotiation	✓ Compare agreed costs for previous placements ✓ Compare placement costs for similar cohorts

Primary use case

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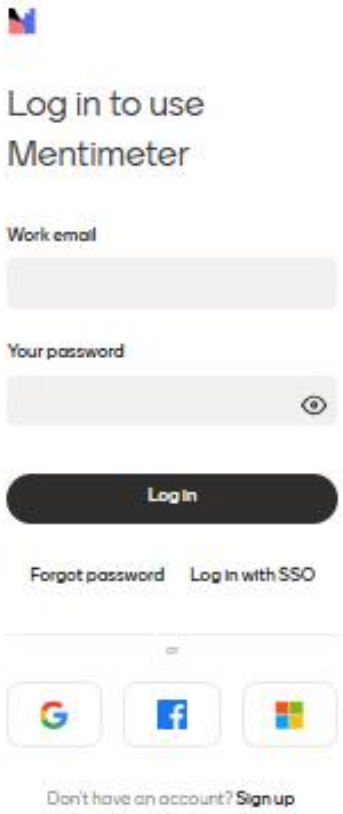

Criteria for designing the specification

- ✓ **Does this field help us answer the priority use case questions?**
- ✓ **Can it be answered in c. 90 seconds?**
- ✓ Others?

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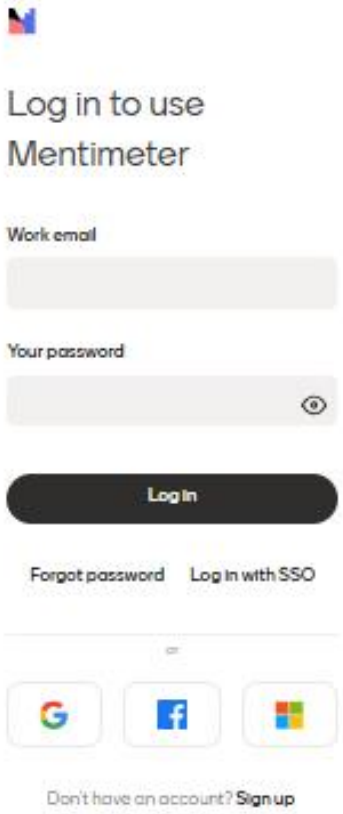


What does our proposed data standard look like? (more detail)

Identifying child

- Unique identifier that links to CMS

Determinants of Availability

- Risks to child and risks to others
- Preferred location given all key locations
- Provision requirements
- Preferred placement type
- Notice timeframe given to find placement

Describing Costs

- Total placement cost agreed at IPA

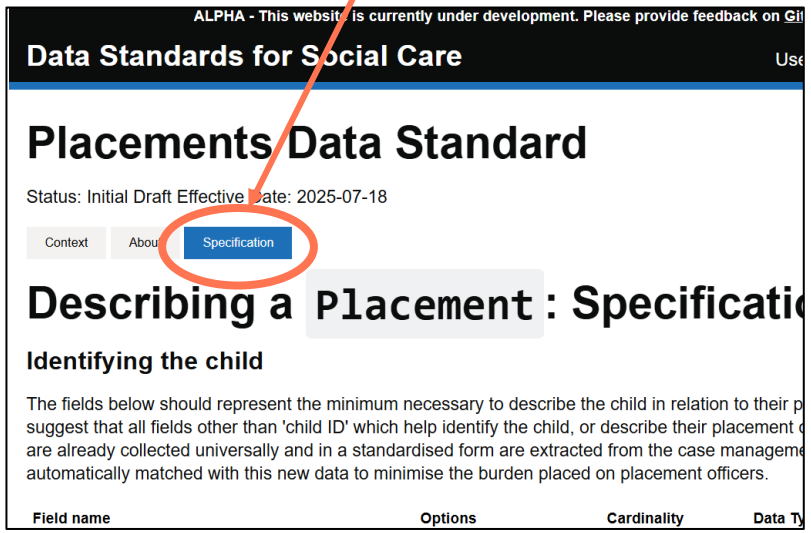
Describing placement

- Actual placement agreed
- Additional support required

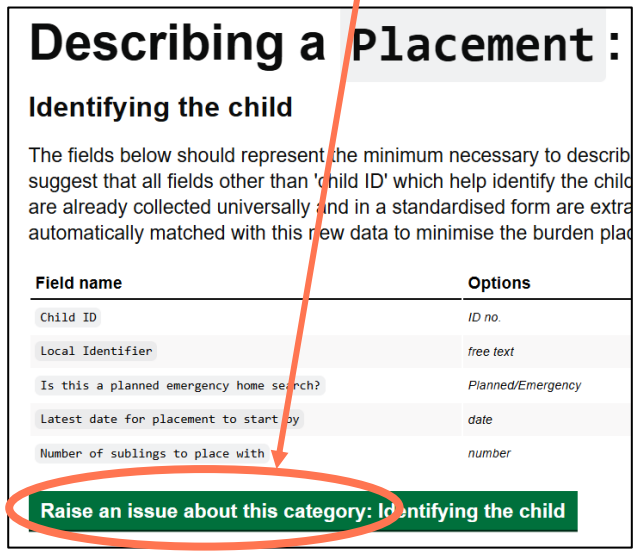
See the full spec at: **socialcaredata.github.io/spec/placements**

Engaging with the specification online

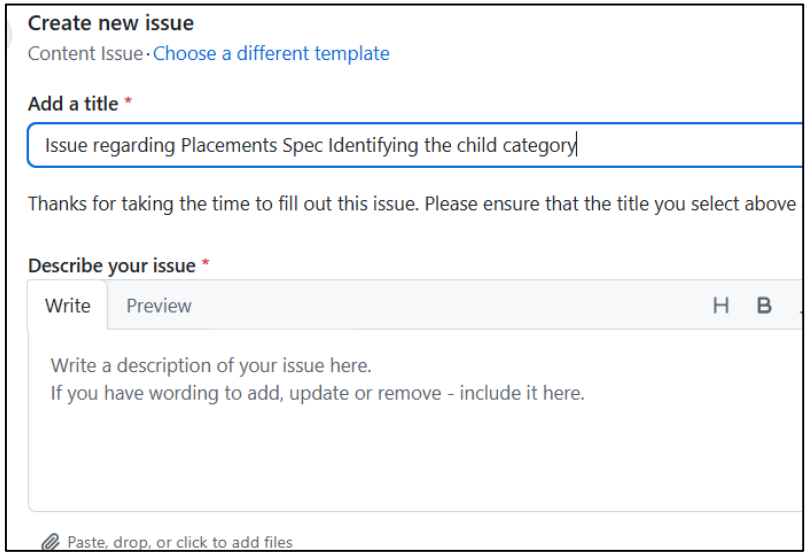
Navigate to ‘specification’ tab



Click ‘raise an issue’



Provide details



See the full spec at: **socialcaredata.github.io/spec/placements**

Discussion

What's next?

	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV
DEVELOPMENT					
Working Group meetings					

Meeting 1

Introduce programme, approach and draft specification

Online review and challenge of proposed specification

Meeting 2

Discuss and agree amendments based on key issues raised online

Further online review and challenge, focused on remaining issues and areas of disagreement

Meeting 3

Finalise standard and agree recommendations for next steps

AoB

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Thank you.

Contact:

Placements:
madeline.goldie@socialfinance.org.uk

MAIS:

Andrew.newman@theodi.org

APPENDIX

What sort of analysis will the standard ‘unlock’?

Jobs	Questions	SSDA903 statutory data (LA level)	Placement standard
Brokerage and contract negotiation	Is the proposed placement cost-effective? (what have we paid previously etc)	× Not possible without manually linked to cost database × No way to compare children by determinants of availability (e.g. risk to child etc)	✓ **Compare agreed costs for previous placements** ✓ **Compare costs for similar cohorts**
Strategic and long-term planning	How many ‘poor’ placement outcomes were there last year?	✓ **Can see how many placed outside home LA, or w/in 20m of home** × Can’t see volume of ‘displacement’ from foster to residential, or sibling splits	✓ **See how many were split from siblings** ✓ **See how many were ‘displaced’ from foster to residential**
	What’s driving these poor placement outcomes (and how could we reduce them?)	✓ **Which demographics / SDQ associated with out-of-LA placement** × Can’t explore drivers of non-pref placements	✓ **Rel’ship between ‘preferred’ placement and determinants like risks to child or notice given**
	Which providers are we most likely to place with? (and for different cohorts)	✓ **Can see which providers are being placed with** ✓ Can’t see which providers available for different cohorts	✓ **See which providers are most likely to be available for specific cohorts** ✓ **See estimated spend per provider**
Quarterly financial planning	Am I on track to spend what I expected to this quarter?	× Can’t see agreed costs	✓ **See estimate of expected costs** ✓ **Explore which cohorts are driving spend**

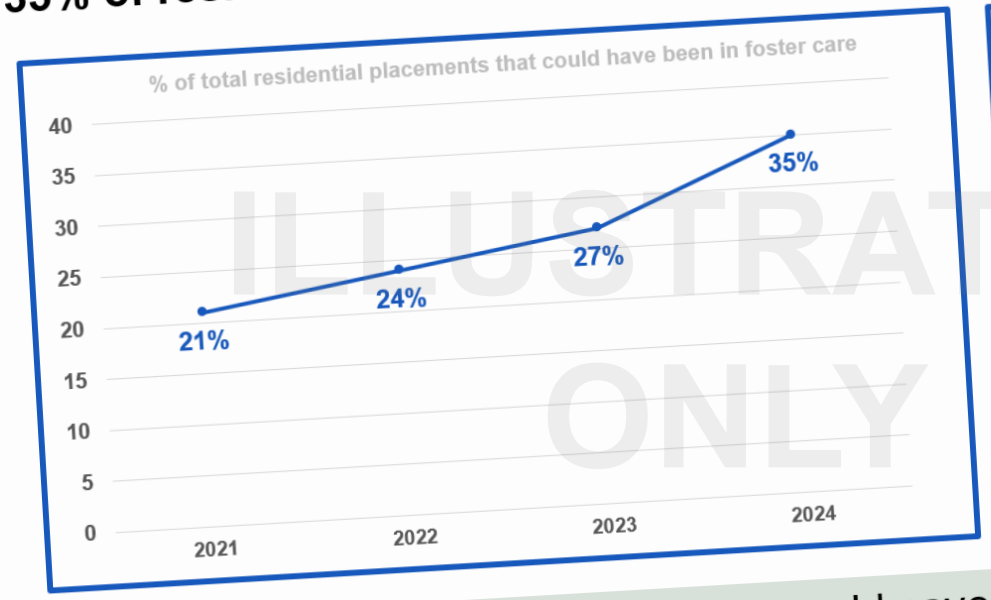
We'll be guided by the programme design principles

Privacy by design
Security by design
Enabling quality data to support analysis
Collaborative data exchange between LAs
Simplicity and ease of implementation
Re-use existing standards
Unambiguous personal data representation

Particularly relevant to the Placement Standard

What sort of analysis will the standard ‘unlock’?

35% of residential placements in 2024 could have been foster placements



ILLUSTRATIVE ONLY

The total cost of placing in residential instead of foster in 2024 was c. **£2m**

Displacement meant 19 children were unnecessarily placed out of area and 15 children were separated from siblings

If trends continue, **we could waste another c. £2.2m in 2025** on unnecessary residential care placements

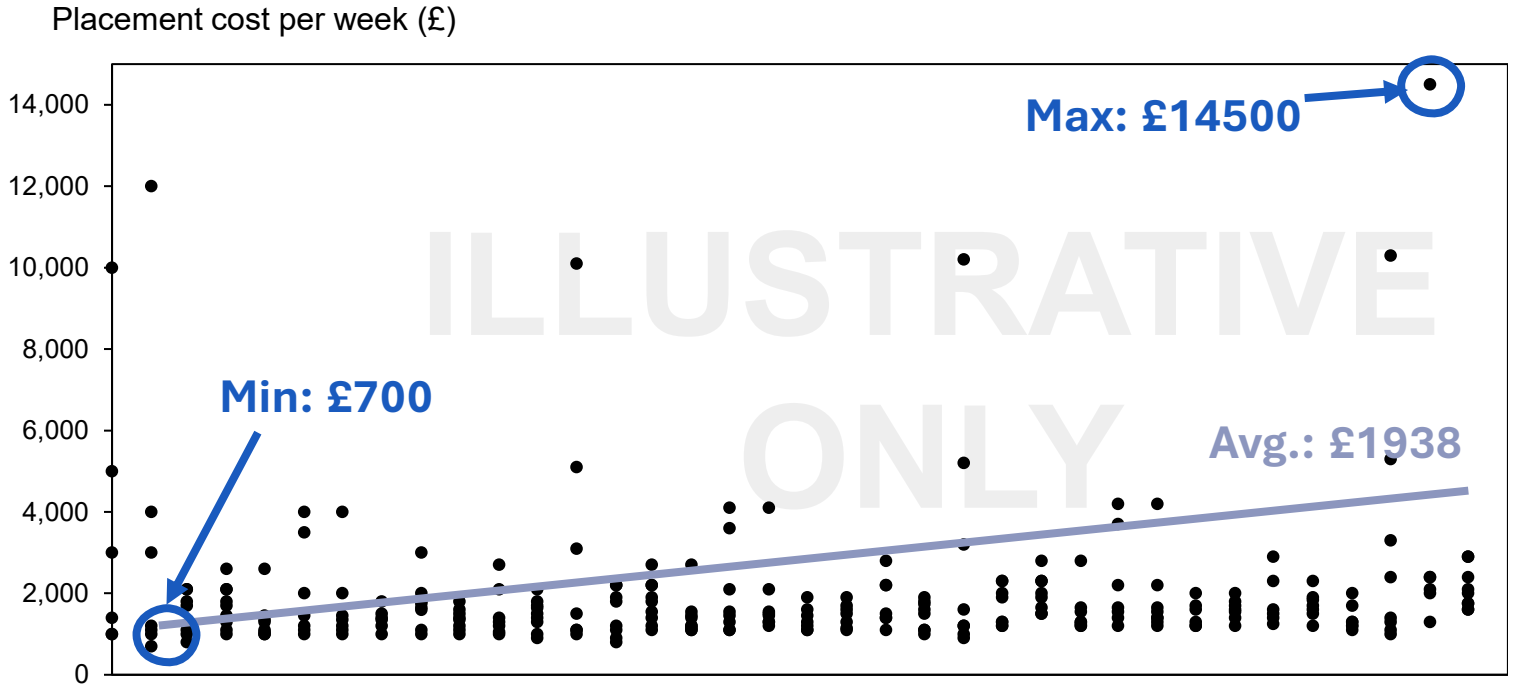
We propose investing the £2.2m we could save from reducing unnecessary residential placements into a new therapeutic foster care programme

What sort of analysis will the standard ‘unlock’?

EXAMPLE ANALYSIS

Time period	Placement type	Age range	Gender	Risks to child	Risks to others
2022-2024	Residential	15-17	Female	Self-harm	Fire setting

What is the range of planned res care costs for girls aged 15-17 with risks of self-harm and fire setting over last 2 years?



What sort of analysis will the standard ‘unlock’?

EXAMPLE ANALYSIS

What types of issues distinguish children who are placed in foster care from those who could be but aren’t?

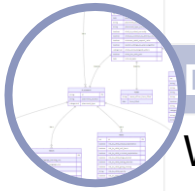
	Volume of placements where any of these risks were recorded:							
	Risk 1	**Risk 2**	**Risk 3**	**Risk 4**	**Risk 5**	**Risk 6**	**1 risk or less**	**3 + risks**
Sought foster / placed in foster	27%	2%	14%	15%	11%	34%	65%	27%
Sought foster / placed in resi care	41%	10%	66%	25%	17%	67%	55%	33%

ILLUSTRATIVE ONLY

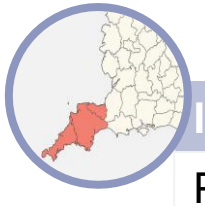
Our proposed standard builds on existing approaches and accounts for frontline experience

Defining needs	Defining costs	Minimising data entry burden
• Reviewed CANS, BERRI and 'All Wales Single referral' • Interviewed 6 providers to understand how they understand need	• Reviewed PNW, White Rose and Southeast approaches to describing costs	• Interviewed placement teams to understand their processes and test 'collectability' of the standard

Placement Standard timeline



	2025					2026					2027	
	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC	Q1	Q2	Q3	Q4	Q1	Q2
DEVELOPMENT												
Working Group meets	●	←6 weeks→	●	●		○	○	○	○	○		○
Standard development	**Placement Standard 1.0**					Standards that address other use placement cases						



IMPLEMENTATION												
Pilot standard in Southwest												
Wider national roll out												

While other models have similar data, our approach aims to give placement teams greater control

	Data captured				Team entering (or 'owning') data		
	Placement costs (child level)	Determinants of Availability *(e.g. home adaptations, additional support etc)*	Preferred vs Got	Child-level Outcomes	Social worker or care worker	Placement Team	Finance team
Southwest Sufficiency dataset	✓	✓	✓			✓	
Placements North West dataset	✓					✓	
White Rose placement dataset	✓					✓	
Southeast placement cost dataset	✓					✓	
West Midlands procurement platform	✓					✓	
Care Cubed	✓					✓	✓
E-brokerage tools (various)	✓		?			✓	
Framework agreements (various)	✓	✓				✓	✓
BERRI	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
CANS	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
IMPOWER Valuing Care	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
Proposed National Placement Standard	✓	✓	✓			✓	

Will align existing approaches to capturing cost data

Will standardise approach to capturing determinants of availability and preferred placement

Takes c. 90 second for placement worker to enter

We know many others are also exploring approaches with similar aims

	Data captured				Team entering (or 'owning') data		
	Placement costs (child level)	Determinants of Availability *(e.g. home adaptations, additional support etc)*	Preferred vs Got	Child-level Outcomes	Social worker or care worker	Placement Team	Finance team
Southwest Sufficiency dataset	✓	✓	✓			✓	
Placements North West dataset	✓					✓	
White Rose placement dataset	✓					✓	
Southeast placement cost dataset	✓					✓	
West Midlands procurement platform	✓					✓	
Care Cubed	✓					✓	✓
E-brokerage tools (various)	✓		?			✓	
Framework agreements (various)	✓	✓				✓	✓
BERRI	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
CANS	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
IMPOWER Valuing Care	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		

A few key trade-offs when designing the standard

Where do you think we should be on each tradeoff? What other trade-offs are there?

Different data standards will likely be needed for each use case

	Possible use cases (illustrative only)					
Data likely needed	**Placement market analysis**	Home search	Outcomes tracking	Contract monitoring	Price comparisons	…?
Determinants of placement availability (e.g. support, risks etc)	✓	✓				
Holistic assessment of individual child needs, strengths etc			✓			
Placement costs (IPA)	✓			✓	✓	
Placement costs (actual)	✓			✓	✓	
Placement costs (itemised)	✓			✓	✓	
Preferred placement	✓					
Actual placement	✓		✓	✓	✓	
Individual child outcomes			✓	✓		
Provider list	✓	✓		✓	✓	
Provider attributes (as relevant to matching)		✓				

Scope of this work

Information about the Working Group

Purpose	Scope	Meeting format
Develop standards that: ✓ Meet the needs of all stakeholders ✓ Directly address requirements identified ✓ Are within the guardrails set by the Steering Group	➢ Own data architecture and technical roadmaps required for implementation and adoption by stakeholders ➢ Research, recommend or create data standards that respond to identified use cases ➢ Collaborate to test the standards ➢ Promote the adoption	• Meet online 6-weekly • Meetings recorded • Open attendance, attendees may change • Supported by shared online workspace to collaborate between meetings